

BKM 8 Enrichment

E1. Stephen E. Robinson: “Since coming to Brigham Young University a few years ago, I have noticed a peculiar and unexpected thing. **New freshmen** arrive at BYU from wards and branches all over the Church. The majority have been in the Church for a relatively long time, even, I suspect, most of their lives, **and they are generally well trained in the peripherals of the gospel**. They know a surprising amount about tithing, the Word of Wisdom, genealogy, LDS dating, food storage, and so forth. Of course all of these are important principles for the Latter-day Saints and make up part of the fullness of the gospel in the latter days. **But these are not central doctrines of the gospel** as taught in all dispensations from the beginning of the world to its end.

“What I noticed about my students was that, as we moved in class from peripheral doctrines of the gospel, many of them became less and less sure of themselves—they were soft in the middle. Some were even more comfortable defining themselves in terms of what they *didn’t* believe (predestination, original sin, and so forth) than in terms of what they *did* believe. **A significant minority did not understand scriptural doctrines such as salvation by grace, justification through faith in Christ, sanctification, atonement, and the meaning and terms of the gospel covenant. They were well taught in the peripherals but not in the vitals of the restored gospel**” (*Believing Christ*, pp. ix-x; underlining mine).

E2. Stephen E. Robinson: “**In team sports**, it doesn’t matter which of the players makes the points. **When one individual scores, the whole team scores**. If the quarterback throws a touchdown ball to the tight end, then it doesn’t matter that the guards never touched the ball, or even that the defense was sitting on the bench. It doesn’t matter that some on the team may have missed their blocks or run the wrong routes. It doesn’t even matter that the second or third string hadn’t yet been in the game. When one member of the team scores, the whole team scores...

“**In making the gospel covenant, we become part of a team whose captain and quarterback is Jesus Christ, a cosmic Heisman Trophy winner who throws nothing but touchdowns**. If we are on his team, we will go undefeated. Even if I miss my block now and then, even if he asks me just to sit on the bench most of the time, as long as he’s the captain, we’re going to win. **But I’ve got to be on his team, not my own and not somebody else’s.**” (*Believing Christ*, 29)

E3. Nancy Jensen:



Florence Chadwick

“It was July 4, 1952. [Florence] Chadwick, who had previously swum the English Channel, now attempted the 21-mile swim from the southern California mainland to Catalina Island. The water was a freezing 48 degrees. **The fog was thick and visibility almost nil. Finally, only a half mile from her destination, she became discouraged and quit.** The next day reporters clamored around her asking why she had quit—had it been the cold water or the distance. It proved to be neither. She responded, **‘I was licked by the fog.’** She then recalled a similar experience while swimming the English Channel. Evidently the fog was likewise engulfing. She was exhausted. As she was about to reach out for her father’s hand in the nearby boat, he pointed to the shore. She raised her head out of the water just long enough to see the land ahead. With that new vision, she pressed on and became the first woman to conquer the English Channel.

“That story teaches a magnificent principle: with increased vision can come increased motivation. **So it is with the Atonement. As our vision of the Atonement is enhanced, our motivation to embrace its full effects is proportionately increased...**

“Every attempt to reflect upon the Atonement, to study it, to embrace it, to express appreciation for it, however small or feeble it may be, will kindle the fires of faith and work its miracle towards a more Christlike life. It is an inescapable consequence of so doing. We become like those things we habitually love and admire. And thus, as we study Christ’s life and live his teachings, we become more like him.” (Tad R. Callister, *The Infinite Atonement*, p. 16-17) (Cited inn Nancy Jensen’s blog.)

E4. Nancy Jensen:

“Wherefore, we shall have a perfect knowledge of all our guilt, and our uncleanness, and our nakedness; and the righteous shall have a perfect knowledge of their enjoyment, and their righteousness, being clothed with purity, yea, even with the robe of righteousness.” (2 Ne. 9:14)

“When his plan is complete, the thing we have lacked, a perfect knowledge, will now be ours. What is it that we will know? What we have become.

“President John Taylor said, ‘The spirit lives where the record of his deeds is kept—that does not die—man cannot kill it; there is no decay associated with it, and it still retains in all its vividness the remembrance of that which transpired before the separation by death of the body and the ever-living spirit...It would be in vain for a man to say then, I did not do so-and-so; the command would be, Unravel and read the record which he has made of himself...’ (Journal of Discourses, 11:78-79)

“A woman who had a **near-death experience** with the afterlife said that, in addition to reliving everything that had happened to her or that she had thought, she also saw ‘the effect of each thought, word, and deed on everyone and anyone who had ever come within my environment or sphere of influence whether I knew them or not (including unknown passersby on the street)...’

“Another man who had **such an experience** reported that he relived his life, but with an omniscient viewpoint: ‘It showed me not only what I had done but even how what I had done had affected other people.’

(Brent and Wendy Top, *Glimpses Beyond Death’s Door*, p. 201; cited in Nancy Jensen’s blog.)

E5. Brad Wilcox: “Christ’s arrangement with us is similar to a mom providing music lessons for her child. Mom pays the piano teacher. Because Mom pays the debt in full, she can turn to her child and ask for something. What is it? Practice! Does the child’s practice pay the piano teacher? No. Does the child’s practice repay Mom for paying the piano teacher? No. Practicing is how the child shows appreciation for Mom’s incredible gift. It is how he takes advantage of the amazing opportunity Mom is giving him to live his life at a higher level. Mom’s joy is found not in getting repaid but in seeing her gift used—seeing her child improve. And so she continues to call for practice, practice, practice.

“If the child see Mom’s requirement of practice as being too overbearing (“Gosh, Mom, why do I need to practice? None of the other kids have to practice! I’m just going to be a professional baseball player anyway!”), perhaps it is because he doesn’t yet see with Mom’s eyes. He doesn’t see how much better his life could be if he would choose to live on a higher plane.

...
“Elder Dallin H. Oaks of the Quorum of the Twelve Apostles has said, ‘The repenting sinner must suffer for his sins, but this suffering has a different purpose than punishment or payment. Its purpose is *change*’ (The

Lord’s Way [1991], 223; emphasis in original). Let put that in terms of the child pianist: The child must practice the piano, but this practice has a different purpose than punishment or payment. Its purpose is change.

“The miracle of the Atonement is not just that we can live after we die but that we can live more abundantly (see John 10:10). The miracle of the Atonement is not just that we can be cleansed and consoled but that we can be transformed (see Romans 8). Scriptures make it clear that no unclean thing can dwell with God (see Alma 40:26), but no unchanged thing will even want to” (“His Grace is Sufficient,” *Ensign*, September 2013).

E6. Elder Theodore M. Burton: “The most basic principles of the gospel are sometimes those least understood. And one of the most fundamental gospel principles is repentance.

“Repentance is a mechanism for personal growth and development. So fundamental is the principle that the Lord stressed its importance **seventy-one times** in the Doctrine and Covenants. Two of those revelations, one following the other in the Doctrine and Covenants, are identical and conclude with these words:

“And now, behold, I say unto you, that the thing which will be of the most worth unto you will be to *declare repentance unto this people*, that you may bring souls unto me, that you may rest *with them* in the kingdom of my Father.” (D&C 15:6; D&C 16:6; italics added.)

“Why would the Lord give two *identical* revelations and have them published in the Doctrine and Covenants, one following the other? The Lord is a Master Teacher; he knows the value of repetition in learning...

“Just what is repentance? Actually, in some ways it is easier to understand what repentance is *not* than to understand what it *is*.

“As a General Authority, I have prepared information for the First Presidency to use in considering applications to readmit repentant transgressors into the Church and to restore priesthood and temple blessings. Many times a bishop will write, ‘I feel he has suffered enough!’ But suffering is not repentance. Suffering comes from lack of complete repentance. A stake president will write, ‘I feel he has been punished enough!’ But punishment is not repentance. Punishment follows disobedience and precedes repentance. A husband will write, ‘My wife has confessed everything!’ But confession is not repentance. Confession is an admission of guilt that occurs as repentance begins. A wife will write, ‘My husband is filled with remorse!’ But remorse is not repentance. Remorse and sorrow continue because a person has not yet fully repented. Suffering, punishment, confession, remorse, and sorrow may sometimes accompany repentance, but they are not repentance. What, then, is repentance?” (“The Meaning of Repentance,” *Ensign*, August 1988)

E7. Stephen E. Robinson: “GIVING HIM EVERYTHING”

Robinson tells the story of “one of the roughest persons” he had ever known. She’d experienced a childhood of abuse and run away and “lived on the streets for years”. She’d roamed the country with a motorcycle gang. “In late middle age, her beauty gone, she spent most of her time in a pub, where the missionaries met her when they went in to get change for a pay phone outside. When she was baptized, many of the members worried that her conversion wouldn’t last, and there were good reasons to suspect it might not.

For a long time after her baptism, this sister still swore like a trooper, even in Church, and never quite lived the Word of Wisdom one hundred percent. On one occasion during her first year in the Church, she lost her temper during a Relief Society meeting and punched out one of the other sisters. Her ex-husband is an alcoholic, and her children have all spent time in jail.” (*Believing Christ*, 95-97. For those who have *Believing Christ*, this story is well worth ponderizing.)

E8. Additional Teaching Ideas (from Lesson #1)

2. Sharing the Book of Mormon

“Consult with the bishopric and the ward mission leader about how members can obtain copies of the Book of Mormon to share with nonmember friends and acquaintances.

“In class, suggest that a class goal this year should be to share the Book of Mormon with nonmember friends and acquaintances. Explain to class members how they may obtain copies of the Book of Mormon, and encourage each class member to give a copy to at least one friend or acquaintance during the year.

“Several times during the year, as the Spirit directs, ask class members if any of them have yet shared a copy of the Book of Mormon. Invite class members who have done this to briefly describe the experience. Continue to encourage class members to share the Book of Mormon with others.” (*Lesson Manual*)

Recommended Reading and Viewing Resources:

Ensign Articles about the Book of Mormon:

1. President Ezra Taft Benson, “[The Book of Mormon—Keystone of our Religion](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1986.
2. Boyd K. Packer, “[The Book of Mormon: Another Testament of Jesus Christ—Plain and Precious Things](#),” *Ensign*, May 2005, 6-9.
3. President Marion G. Romney, “[The Book of Mormon](#),” *Ensign*, May 1980, 67).
4. James A. Cullimore (Assistant to the Twelve), “[The Book of Mormon](#),” *Ensign*, May 1976.

Best Ensign Article(s) on the Atonement:

1. Brad Wilcox, “[His Grace Is Sufficient](#),” *Ensign*, September 2013.

2. Elder Theodore M. Burton, “[The Meaning of Repentance](#),” *Ensign*, August 1988.

Best Book(s) on the Atonement:

1. Stephen E. Robinson, *Believing Christ: The Parable of the Bicycle and Other Good News* (Salt Lake City, Utah: Deseret Book Company, 1992).
2. Tad R. Callister, *The Infinite Atonement* (Salt Lake City, Utah: Deseret Book Company, 2000).

Scholarly Resources of Interest:

1. [Book of Mormon Central.org](#).
 2. [2016 Gospel Doctrine—Recommended Resources on the Book of Mormon \(updated\)](#), Ben S., Times and Seasons, December 19, 2015.
 3. “[Complexity, Consistency, Ignorance, and Probabilities](#),” Melvin J. Thorne, *Book of Mormon Authorship: Revisited*, Chapter 7.
 4. BYU Studies Quarterly, at [LDSGospelDoctrine.net](#), Select 2016 BofM. Select **8**) 2 Nephi 6-10.. Select BYU Studies GD lesson material.
 5. “[The Plain and Precious Parts](#),” John Welch, Chapter 10 in *Reexploring the Book of Mormon*, pp. 37-40.
- Chiasmus:**
John W. Welch, “[A Book You Can Respect](#),” *Ensign*, Sept. 1977, 45-58.

Blogs of Interest:

1. Nancy Jensen, at [LDSGospelDoctrine.net](#), Select 2016 BofM. Select **8**) 2 Nephi 6-10. Select Nancy Jensen Gospel Doctrine lesson material blog “LDS Gospel Doctrine Plus”.
2. Gerald Smith, at [LDSGospelDoctrine.net](#), Select 2016 BofM. Select **8**) 2 Nephi 6-10. Select Gerald Smith Gospel Doctrine lesson blog “Joel’s Monastery”.
3. Lenet H. Read, at [LDSGospelDoctrine.net](#), Select 2016 BofM. Select **8**) 2 Nephi 6-10. Select Lenet Read GD lessons.

Non-Mormon Views of Mormons or the Gospel:

1. Stephen H. Webb, “[Mormonism obsessed with Christ](#),” First Things, accessed 1/16/16.

When you read this article by a former evangelical Christian who converted to Catholicism, Ponderize the BKM 3 Quotes: ¶1 and ¶2 with it. Stephen H. Webb is professor of religion and philosophy at Wabash College.

2. Joel J. Miller, “[The dangers of DIY spirituality](#),” *Theology That Sticks*, February 22, 2016. [NOTE: Joel is not a Mormon, but as I read his article, I thought of Christ: of His Atonement; of His words, and of His Church here on earth. We should not try to do-it-ourselves.]

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